

Al Pastor

Achiote-adobo · griddle-charred · taco-truck style · freezer workflow

PORTION	MARINATE	SLICE	FREEZER
450 g bags	4 hr-overnight	3–4 mm vs grain	3+ months

KEY TARGETS

char outside, tender inside — judged by eye

Chile rehydration	soft, 20–30 min	Griddle temp	oil shimmers
Adobo consistency	coats a spoon	Char level	crispy, blackened
Slice thickness	3–4 mm	Final texture	charred, tender

ADOBO FORMULA

% of pork weight — árbol 1% = medium; 0.5% mild, 1.5% hot

Pork butt boneless, sliced 3–4 mm vs grain	100%	3500 g
Guajillo dried, stemmed + seeded	6.5%	228 g
Ancho dried, stemmed + seeded	3.3%	116 g
Árbol dried — heat dial	1%	35 g
Achiote paste brick, El Yucateco	9%	315 g
Orange juice fresh, not concentrate	13%	455 ml
White vinegar distilled / white wine	6.5%	228 ml
Garlic fresh, ~2 heads	2%	70 g
Cumin, ground	0.1%	3.5 g
Mexican oregano not Italian	0.1%	3.5 g
Black pepper	0.05%	1.75 g
Cloves, ground scant — they dominate	0.025%	~1 g
Salt Diamond Crystal, by wt	1.5%	52 g

Salt is brand-dependent — convert by weight: the 52 g is **Diamond Crystal** for 3.5 kg. Morton Kosher = **60%** of that (31 g); table salt = **50%** (26 g). **Achiote substitute** if no brick: ~8 g ground annatto + ~6 g paprika per 450 g pork — close, not identical. Formula scales linearly: weigh the pork, multiply the percentages.

Make Ahead & Cook

PREP & FREEZE

build the bags ahead — marinate happens in the freezer

- 1 Toast chiles:** dry skillet, medium. Guajillo, ancho, árbol **30–60 sec/side** until fragrant and pliable — don't burn (burnt = bitter adobo).
- 2 Rehydrate:** cover with hot water, soak **20–30 min** until fully soft. Drain, reserving a little soaking liquid.
- 3 Blend adobo:** chiles + achote + OJ + vinegar + garlic + spices + salt to smooth. Loosen with soaking liquid **15 ml at a time** — it should coat a spoon, not run watery.
- 4 Semi-freeze the pork:** whole butt in the freezer **45–60 min** until firm but not solid — this is what makes clean slicing possible.
- 5 Slice: 3–4 mm against the grain.** Thin is critical; work fast before the pork softens.
- 6 Combine:** toss the slices in the adobo until fully coated; massage it in.
- 7 Portion + freeze:** into quart bags (**450 g** each), press flat, remove air, label with the date, freeze.

COOK FROM FROZEN

ripping-hot griddle — sear, don't steam

- 8 Thaw:** fridge overnight, or a cold-water bath **30–45 min**.
- 9 Griddle:** cast iron / flat-top, high heat, light oil. Single layer, don't crowd. Char **60–90 sec**, flip once, char the other side.
- 10 Chop + onion:** push pork aside, add fresh sliced white onion; char it while chopping the pork with metal spatulas, then mix together on the griddle.
- 11 Serve:** double-stacked corn tortillas, al pastor, charred onion, cilantro, fresh lime, flaky salt on top.

TROUBLESHOOTING

PROBLEM	CAUSE	FIX
Mushy texture	Sliced too thick; steamed not seared	Thinner slices, higher heat, don't crowd
Pale, no char	Griddle not hot enough	Wait for the oil to shimmer, almost smoke
Bitter adobo	Chiles burnt during toast	Toast less — just until pliable
Bland	Under-salted adobo	Salt the marinade; finish with flaky salt
Dry meat	Overcooked	Pull earlier — pork keeps cooking off-heat